events inside Burma than at any time since the late 1950s. In reality, the military repression after 1992 had resolved nothing and, as we shall see, all it took was a single unexpected event to force the regime to grant major concessions.

International relations

There was an international element to the domestic politics of Burma in this era.[58] As noted above, at least one of the border wars that were such a feature of the 1950s was closely related to US attempts to destabilise the new Chinese Communist regime. Equally, the military in particular had a profound fear of foreign intervention, whether in the form of invasion or of external interference in domestic politics. Despite this apparent preference for isolationism, there were important international influences on Burmese domestic politics even if, for the most part, the outside world took little interest in the problems of Burma throughout this period.

Britain, as the former colonial power, originally envisaged that Burma would join the Commonwealth on independence in 1948.[59] However, the new state, suspicious of its former colonial ruler, declined the invitation. Given the larger challenges of Anglo–Indian and Anglo–Pakistani relations after those countries became independent in 1947,[60] Britain abandoned its initial attempts to influence the new country.[61] Britain had originally provided aid at the request of the new government to stabilise its finances, and, as elsewhere, offered to allow the new country to continue to use sterling as its currency. More importantly, the British were trying to construct an alliance of former colonies, and Australia and New Zealand to construct an anti-Communist bloc across South East Asia.[62]

However, the new Burmese government saw the British as seeking to continue their colonial dominance by other means and the British were further tainted by their support for Karen aspirations to greater federalism. By mid-1949, Burmese–British relations had effectively ended over revelations that at least some British officials had plotted a coup to bring the Karen to power, as they were seen to be more reliably anti-Communist than U Nu's official government.[63]

In the 1950s, insofar as Burma had systemic external links they were with international bodies such as the early versions of what became the